

World in Brief: Trump's crypto bonanza; America declines to renew big trade pact



Photograph: AP

Donald Trump dismissed criticism of his [cryptocurrency profits](#), after a new disclosure revealed that he earned more than \$1bn from such ventures last year. This was driven by sales of Mr Trump's meme coin, \$TRUMP, as well as deals linked to his family's crypto firm, World Liberty Financial. The president said external institutions, whom he "never" speaks to, run his finances. The White House denied that there was a conflict of interest.

The **Trump administration** said it would not renew [America's trade pact](#) with **Canada and Mexico** and instead pursue separate deals with each. The decision was expected: Mr Trump has soured on the agreement with America's biggest trading partners, despite negotiating it during his first term. The deal will remain in force until 2036, unless one of the countries withdraws, with reviews occurring annually.

A Swedish court ordered **Google** to pay \$2bn in damages to **PriceRunner**, a price comparison website, for manipulating search results to favour its own shopping service. PriceRunner is owned by Klarna, a Swedish tech company. It is the largest payout ever awarded in a competition case in Sweden. Google, which is expected to appeal the fine, faces similar cases in Britain and Italy.

Kroger, one of America's biggest grocers, announced a \$1.65bn deal to buy Giant Eagle, a food and pharmacy chain. It is Kroger's first big acquisition since regulators [blocked a \\$25bn merger](#) with Albertsons, another supermarket, in 2024. The deal will expand Kroger's access to regional markets—and comes amid growing competition from retailers such as Walmart and Amazon to win over [price-conscious consumers](#).

The EU introduced a €3 (\$3.4) fee on low-value imports, ending a duty-free exemption for parcels valued under €150. The move targets Chinese e-commerce brands like Temu and Shein. Officials said that 5.8bn such parcels entered the bloc last year, up from 1.4bn in 2022. In 2025 America ended [a similar exemption](#) for packages worth less than \$800.

Police in **South Africa** said they arrested more than 900 people at [anti-migrant protests](#) that swept the country on Tuesday. Vigilante groups had marked the day as a “deadline” for illegal immigrants to leave, which raised concerns about a possible spike in violence. Police said that most of the protests were peaceful, though some were accompanied by looting and other disruption.

Mr Trump took his first trip on a luxury jet given to America by Qatar. He accepted the Boeing 747 after complaining about the shabbiness of the existing **Air Force One** planes, prompting some lawmakers to complain that the Gulf country was seeking to buy influence. The president's new toy has had a \$400m refit, including a paint job similar to his personal jet.

Figure of the day: Six, the number of goals Lionel Messi and Kylian Mbappé have scored so far at the 2026 World Cup. Our [Back Story](#) columnist examines why this year's tournament belongs to football's superstars.

US in Brief: Born this way



Photograph: Reuters

The **Supreme Court** struck down Donald Trump's executive order to end **birthright citizenship** for babies born in America to undocumented or temporary migrants, declaring it unconstitutional. Mr Trump subsequently suggested, inaccurately, that he can "easily make it up in Congress through Legislation". (Such a law would face significant legal hurdles.) The president **had better luck** regarding state bans on transgender athletes competing in women's sport: all nine justices agreed they can be excluded under a federal civil-rights law. The conservative majority also relaxed restrictions on campaign spending.

Members of the **House of Representatives** headed home early after right-wing Republicans voted down a procedural motion, stalling the week's legislative agenda. Conservatives want Republican leaders to advance Mr Trump's **save America Act**, which seeks to end most mail-in ballots and to require voters to present proof of citizenship and photo identification, as well as a border-security bill. Separately, the House failed to pass a war-powers resolution that would have required Congress to approve any American involvement in Israeli military operations in Lebanon.

The progressive wing of the Democratic Party continued its **winning streak**. In **Colorado's** Democratic primary for governor,

Phil Weiser, the attorney-general, defeated Michael Bennet, a prominent senator (whose brother writes for *The Economist*), after casting Mr Bennet as a Washington insider—an upset that signals voter frustration with establishment figures. Meanwhile, Melat Kiros, a 29-year-old, defeated Diana DeGette, a 29-year incumbent, in the 1st District’s House primary. Manny Rutinel, a progressive state representative, also ousted Shannon Bird, a moderate former state representative, in the 8th.

The **Food and Drug Administration** allowed some **Zyn nicotine pouches** to be marketed to adults as safer than cigarettes, by claiming their use carries a lower risk of diseases including lung cancer and heart disease. The smoke-free products made by **Philip Morris International**, a tobacco giant, were authorised for sale last year. They are the first nicotine pouches to receive the designation.

Germany's coalition attempts a reboot



Photograph: Shutterstock

If you feel sorry for Germany's footballers, ejected from the World Cup by Paraguay on Monday, spare a thought for the country's politicians. A promised "autumn of reforms" last year fizzled out, Germany's economy **remains stuck** and its coalition, which unites Friedrich Merz's conservatives with the Social Democrats, has **squabbled endlessly**. On Wednesday senior figures from the ruling parties hope to reboot with a meeting designed to agree on tax, labour-market and other reforms.

Last week moods improved when the parties agreed that reforms to Germany's pension system, proposed by a state-backed commission, should be implemented in full. But the topics on Wednesday's agenda, especially how to fund tax cuts for low earners, could prove harder to solve. What was supposed to be a one-day session could drag on, possibly into Friday. Going to extra time, if that is what it takes, beats going home.

Bending Spoons lists for American IPO



Photograph: Getty Images

Bending Spoons, a conglomerate based in Milan, will list its shares on America's tech-heavy Nasdaq exchange on Wednesday. The IPO values the company at around \$18bn, in what would be a rare [European-tech](#) success story.

Bending Spoons buys ailing digital businesses at low prices and fixes them up. It has done so for around 50 companies since its founding in 2013, including Vimeo, a video platform, and WeTransfer, a file-sharing service. The firm's revenue comes from monthly subscriptions for its apps, and has grown from \$387m in 2023 to \$1.3bn in 2025. But a recent buying spree has loaded the firm with debt. And some of the older digital brands it forked out for are under threat from artificial intelligence. Bending Spoons says AI is actually an opportunity, noting improvements in its productivity and marketing. The firm's stock-market debut will show if investors are convinced.

Taking stock of the Supreme Court



Photograph: Getty Images

America's Supreme Court wrapped up its term with mixed results for Donald Trump's agenda. It upheld state bans, favoured by the administration, on [transgender athletes competing in women's sport](#): all nine justices agreed that biological males can be excluded from female sports under Title IX, a federal civil-rights law that bans sex discrimination in schools. All but three added that such bans do not violate the constitution. The conservative majority also relaxed restrictions on campaign spending.

The president was less thrilled about the court's 6-3 decision to strike down his [executive order to end birthright citizenship](#) for babies born in America to noncitizens. He wrote online, inaccurately, that he can "easily make it up in Congress through Legislation". Still, this defeat could not obscure the term's conservative bottom line: ruling in *Trump v Slaughter* on Monday, justices [handed him more power](#) by allowing him to fire commissioners of independent agencies at will. Mr Trump concluded that his party "was treated very fairly" by the court.

India revamps a big rural safety net



Photograph: Getty Images

For two decades, the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act has been the cornerstone of India's rural-development strategy. The programme guarantees 100 days of minimum-wage employment on public works for every rural household that asks for it. Despite patchy implementation, the scheme had nearly 60m households participate in 2024-25. Studies show it is an effective safety net that also boosts rural incomes and empowers women.

On Wednesday MGNREGA was to be replaced by a new programme, known as VB-G RAM G, which India's government insists will improve on the old one by increasing the number of days of work available. Critics, however, say it is a downgrade that erodes its predecessor's legal guarantees. State governments will have to pay more than they are currently to fund the scheme; several are considering challenging the change in the Supreme Court. Meanwhile forecasters are predicting a [historically weak monsoon](#) in the coming weeks, which will strain rural livelihoods—and put the new programme to the test.

The lure of the rising sun



Photograph: Getty Images

For the past two years the World Travel Index has deemed Japan the world's best destination. Last year a record 42.7m holiday-goers visited the country. But tourists may soon sense they are less welcome. From Wednesday Japan's government will raise the visa fee from ¥3,000 (\$19) to ¥15,000 (\$92)—the first increase in nearly 50 years.

The decision is a response to a [souring mood](#). Overtourism has become a political issue, in part thanks to Sanseito, a small populist-right party. Viral clips of unruly visitors, like one of a tourist doing pull-ups on the sacred *torii* gate of a shrine, have provoked outrage. But the higher visa fee may not deter visitors. The lure of Japanese culture remains strong. The value of the yen has fallen to 162 to the dollar, a 40-year low. Holiday-makers will have to pay a bit more to enter Japan, but they'll save money while they're there.

Tokyo drift

Yen per \$, Inverted scale



Source: Haver Analytics

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Arthur Wellesley, a British field marshal, is better known by his aristocratic title. What is it?

Tuesday: Which actor played Roseanne Barr's husband in the sitcom *Roseanne*?

*He who hasn't tasted bitter things
hasn't earned sweet things.*

Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz